WASHINGTON, DC, UNITED STATES

National Museum of Asian Art: Masterpieces

Screens, scrolls, fans and framed pictures ask for different kinds of looking.



Hokusai's *Breaking Waves* is a tall painting on silk, not a version of the familiar horizontal wave print. *Mount Fuji and Enoshima* occupies folding screens. Their subjects can be described as landscapes, but their physical forms give them quite different relationships to a room and to a viewer.

The format is a useful starting point for this selection. A fan's curve limits one scene; an expanse of unpainted paper makes a small bird conspicuous; a screen carries a vine across successive panels. The American and European works here provide comparisons without making those traditions interchangeable. Begin with what kind of object each image occupies, then consider how the painted marks use its particular edges and intervals.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-museum-asian-art

The selection · 20

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   Katsushika Hokusai · 1847
2. Mount Fuji and Enoshima
   Katsushika Hokusai · c. 1825-1831
3. Rats and Rice Bales
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4. Branch of Medlars
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5. Peddler and Child Looking at the Moon
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15. Snow-Covered Grasses and Pine
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16. Low Tide
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    James Abbott McNeill Whistler · 1870-1875
18. Bognor
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20. Emperor Minghuang and Yang Guifei
    Kanō Eitoku · 16th century

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Breaking Waves

Katsushika Hokusai

1847 · Ink and colour on silk · National Museum of Asian Art



Katsushika Hokusai. Breaking Waves. Katsushika Hokusai; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1905.276. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Foam curls above dark water beside the rocks, its fine edges contrasting with the weight below. Hokusai concentrates the action in a narrow upright field more than a metre high. The direction matters: the wave climbs and breaks within the scroll rather than spreading across a panoramic view. Its material is painted silk, not the paper of a printed impression.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1905.276

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Mount Fuji and Enoshima

Katsushika Hokusai

c. 1825-1831 · Ink and colour on paper · National Museum of Asian Art



Katsushika Hokusai. Mount Fuji and Enoshima. Katsushika Hokusai; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1904.175-176. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Low water and distant land extend towards Fuji across the screen's panels. The landscape belongs to an object that folds, so its presentation need not occupy one flat plane. Following the view means attending to both the painted distance and the physical surface in front of it. A photograph laid out flat can conceal this second kind of space.

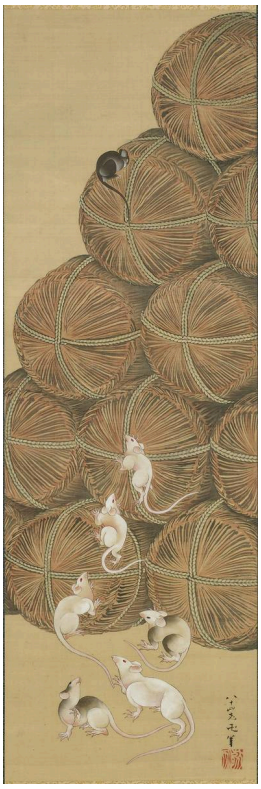
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1904.175-176

03 / 20

Rats and Rice Bales

Katsushika Hokusai

1843 · Ink and colour on silk · National Museum of Asian Art



Katsushika Hokusai. Rats and rice bales. Katsushika Hokusai; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1904.132. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The small rats animate the spaces around the heavy bales. Hokusai allows their scattered positions to break up the grain's stacked mass without filling the surrounding field. Straw and fur require different kinds of marks, and their contrast makes the scale difference especially legible. The modest subject gives close looking plenty to do without a complicated background.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1904.132

04 / 20

Branch of Medlars

Kano Tan'yū

17th century · Ink and colour on paper · National Museum of Asian Art



Kano Tan'yū. A branch of medlars. Kano Tan'yū; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1904.122. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The branch supplies a continuous curve from which stems, leaves and fruit extend. Kanō Tan'yū changes the breadth and weight of the marks to distinguish those parts. Unpainted paper keeps their differences exposed. The plant can be recognised with relatively little description because the strokes have separate jobs, rather than all serving as an even covering of detail.

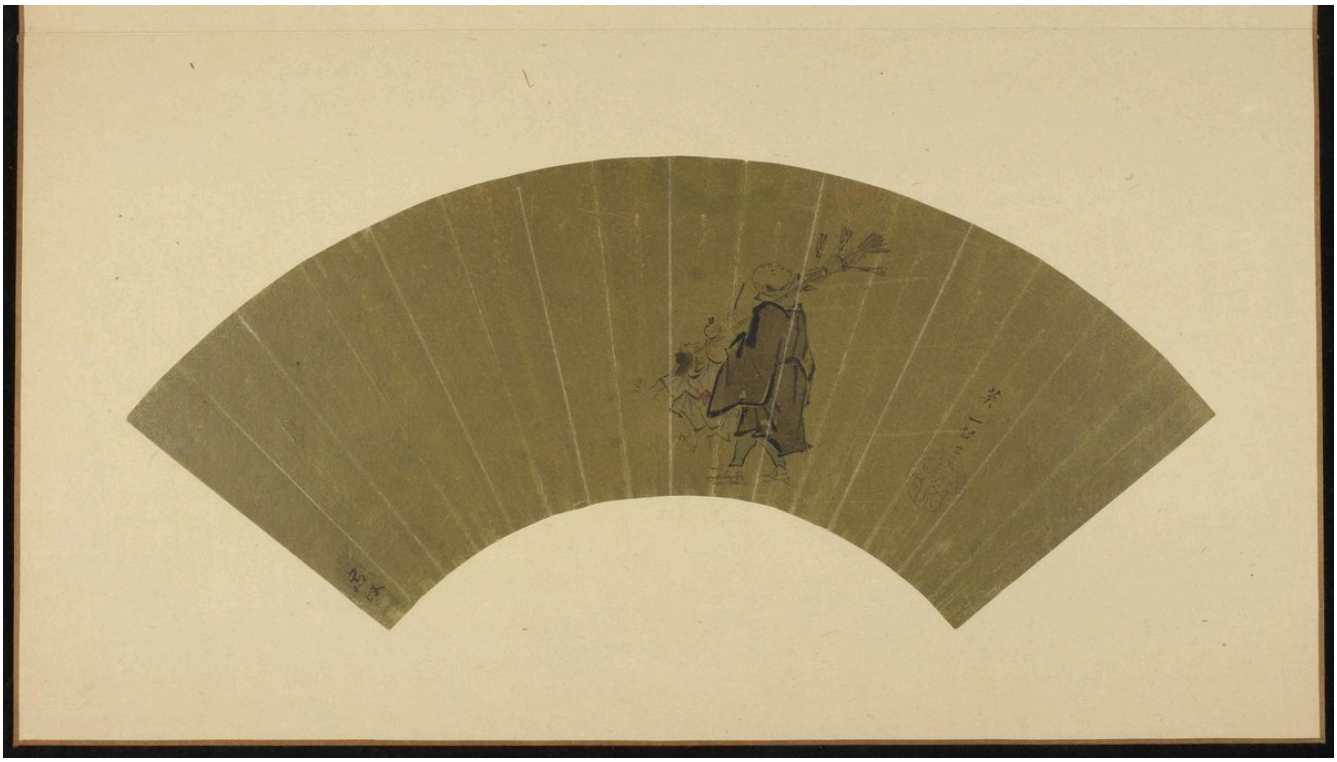
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1904.122

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Peddler and Child Looking at the Moon

Hanabusa Itchō

1615-1868 · Ink and colour on imitation gold · National Museum of Asian Art



Hanabusa Itchō. A peddler and a child looking at the moon. Hanabusa Itchō; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1907.657. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The peddler and child share a direction of attention, leaving a broad area above them for their upward look. The fan-shaped boundary gathers the small figures into its curve. Hanabusa Itchō makes their relationship readable without a detailed exchange of expressions: two bodies looking towards the same thing can establish companionship before the viewer knows anything else about them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1907.657

06 / 20

Arashiyama in Snow

Andō Hiroshige

19th century · Ink and colour on silk · National Museum of Asian Art



Andō Hiroshige. Arashiyama in Snow. Andō Hiroshige; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1903.291. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Dark branches hold their shape against the pale snow, providing enough contrast to preserve the landscape's structure. Hiroshige's compact painted view sits within a taller mounting. It is worth distinguishing the two: the surrounding object changes the scale and pace of encountering the scene, while the image itself relies on a sparse set of marks to describe winter.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1903.291

07 / 20

Bird and Bamboo

Kano Tan'yū

17th century · Ink on paper · National Museum of Asian Art



Kano Tan'yū. Bird on a bamboo branch. Kano Tan'yū; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1904.367. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The bird occupies only a small portion of the tall field, yet the unpainted area gives it unusual prominence. Bamboo stems and leaves provide enough company to locate it without crowding it. Tan'yū makes scale depend on attention as well as measurement. A small figure can command a large surface when little else competes with its few defining marks.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1904.367

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Bodhidharma

Kano Tan'yū

17th century · Ink on paper · National Museum of Asian Art



Kano Tan'yū. Bodhidharma. Kano Tan'yū; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1904.368. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The robed figure sits low within a long pale field. A small number of dark strokes establish head and garment, leaving most of the surface undescribed. That emptiness does not need to be assigned a single symbolic meaning to matter. It makes the relation between the compact body and its extensive surroundings the scroll's dominant compositional fact.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1904.368

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Courtesan beneath a Mosquito Net

Kunisada

1855 · Ink and colour on silk · National Museum of Asian Art



Kunisada. Courtesan beneath a Mosquito Net. Kunisada; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Purchase — Harold P. Stern Memorial Fund; F1995.17. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The hanging green fabric both reveals and encloses the woman. Kunisada fits the net, patterned clothing and bending pose into the scroll's length, with writing occupying another area above. The barrier becomes part of how the figure is presented rather than an incidental furnishing. Her visibility is mediated by a surface inside the image as well as by the image itself.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1995.17

10 / 20

Grape Vines

Kanō Eitoku

1568-1615 · Colour and gold on paper · National Museum of Asian Art



Kanō Eitoku. Grape vines 葡萄図屏風. Kanō Eitoku; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1903.242. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Dark stems connect scattered leaves and grape clusters across gold-ground panels. The vine's growth supplies a form flexible enough to cross the divisions of a folding screen. Gold has a physical response to surrounding light unlike that of the dark painted marks. The object can therefore change in appearance without any change to the arrangement of its branches.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1903.242

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Hollyhocks

Ogata Kōrin

1615-1868 · Ink on paper · National Museum of Asian Art



Ogata Kōrin. Hollyhocks. Ogata Kōrin; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1904.335. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The flowering stem gives continuity to separated leaves and blossoms. Kōrin does not fill every interval, allowing the individual marks to retain their character against the paper. The plant is held together by a small number of connections. Following those connections can be more informative than treating the empty areas as gaps that description has somehow failed to complete.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1904.335

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Landscape with Pavilions

Attributed to Ma Yuan (date conflict)

16th century · Ink on silk · National Museum of Asian Art



Ma Yuan. Landscape: pavilions on a mountain side; a stream below. Ma Yuan; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1909.245c. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Dark foreground forms lead towards pale water and distance within a fan mounted as an album leaf. Its catalogue contains a real difficulty: Ma Yuan's name appears alongside a sixteenth-century date, centuries after his activity. Those entries cannot be treated as a settled attribution. The small landscape can still be examined through its arrangement of near branches, buildings and receding space.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1909.245c

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Peacock

Mori Sosen

1786 · Colour and ink on silk · National Museum of Asian Art



Mori Sosen. Peacock. Mori Sosen; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1898.6. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The long plumage extends the bird through much of the lower field, giving its body an unusually expansive continuation. Mori Sosen distinguishes feathers from nearby vegetation through changes in the small marks. Ornament and animal remain connected: the tail can be followed as a pattern, but its attachment to a standing, weight-bearing creature keeps the image from becoming pure decoration.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1898.6

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Running Water and Autumn Plants

Ogata Kōrin

1658-1868 · Colour, ink, and silver on paper · National Museum of Asian Art



Ogata Kōrin. Running water, autumn grasses and flowers. Ogata Kōrin; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1905.232. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Bands of water carry the eye across the broad screen, while plants interrupt them at unequal intervals. The current provides continuity without imposing a rigid repeat. The recorded materials include silver as well as colour and ink, a reminder that a reproduction's apparent colour cannot by itself identify a metallic surface or predict its response to changing room light.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1905.232

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Snow-Covered Grasses and Pine

Ogata Kenzan

1690-1868 · Ink and colour on paper · National Museum of Asian Art



Ogata Kenzan. Snow-laden grasses and Snow-laden pine branches. Ogata Kenzan; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1897.31a-b. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The two fan-shaped fields retain their curved limits inside the mounting. Kenzan makes snow and dark foliage respond to those boundaries rather than disguising them as rectangular views. The paired presentation encourages comparison between different plant forms. It is also part of the object's identity: these are two related painted areas catalogued together, not two interchangeable isolated pictures.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1897.31a-b

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Low Tide

James Abbott McNeill Whistler

1883-1884 · Oil on wood panel · National Museum of Asian Art



James Abbott McNeill Whistler. Low Tide. James Abbott McNeill Whistler; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1902.156a-b. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The exposed shore occupies a broad area beneath boats and waterfront structures. Whistler binds the view with restrained blues and browns, allowing working objects to remain present without becoming separate incidents. The tide's withdrawal gives the landscape its particular proportions. A large, relatively quiet interval of ground can do as much compositional work as the busier band beyond it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1902.156a-b

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Battersea

James Abbott McNeill Whistler

1870-1875 · Oil on canvas · National Museum of Asian Art



James Abbott McNeill Whistler. Nocturne: Blue and Silver--Battersea Reach. James Abbott McNeill Whistler; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1902.97a-b. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Boats and shore forms have to be distinguished within closely related green-blue tones. Whistler provides enough information to suggest a river without giving every object a decisive outline. The difficulty is productive: attention shifts towards spacing and tonal difference. The broad frame belongs to the encounter too, though it should not be mistaken for part of the painted view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1902.97a-b

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Bognor

James Abbott McNeill Whistler

1871-1876 · Oil on canvas · National Museum of Asian Art



James Abbott McNeill Whistler. Nocturne: Blue and Silver--Bognor. James Abbott McNeill Whistler; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1906.103a-b. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Small figures and boats establish the beach's scale, while thin horizontal divisions keep the view open. Whistler leaves no central event to compete with the intervals of shore, sea and sky. The scattered details are necessary but modest. Their restraint allows the space between things to remain as noticeable as the things themselves.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1906.103a-b

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Portrait of Whistler

Henri Fantin-Latour

1865 · Oil on canvas mounted on aluminum panel · National Museum of Asian Art



Henri Fantin-Latour. Portrait of Whistler. Henri Fantin-Latour; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1906.276a-b. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Fantin-Latour offers few surroundings through which to identify the sitter's profession. Dark clothing and background bring the turned face forward without the assistance of brushes or a palette. The painting gives Whistler a different kind of presence from the landscapes nearby: here he is the subject of another person's selective attention, rather than the organizer of a view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1906.276a-b

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Emperor Minghuang and Yang Guifei

Kanō Eitoku

16th century · Ink, colour, and gold on paper · National Museum of Asian Art



Kanō Eitoku. The Chinese Emperor Minghuang and his concubine Yang Guifei, with attendants on a terrace. Kanō Eitoku; Freer Gallery of Art Collection, Smithsonian Institution, Washington, DC; Gift of Charles Lang Freer; F1900.10. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The Chinese emperor and Yang Guifei appear in an idealised palace setting painted on Japanese screens. Architecture divides their company into connected areas across the gold ground. The subject's place of origin and the object's place of making must be kept distinct. The image records the circulation and reinterpretation of a Chinese story, not a direct view of the historical court.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: F1900.10

Read the object as well as the image

Check whether a reproduction shows the full screen, the painted area alone or a scroll with its mounting. Those choices change apparent proportions. Several catalogue dates here are broad period ranges, and the Ma Yuan entry remains internally inconsistent; avoid using them as exact timeline points. Current display of light-sensitive works must be checked separately with the museum.

Further reading

The Spirit of Japanese Art

Yoné Noguchi · Read free · English

Yone Noguchi's essays introduce Japanese painters through the judgments of an early twentieth-century writer. Compare his language with the objects themselves, and keep the book's historical viewpoint distinct from a current museum catalogue.

Along the Riverbank: Chinese Paintings from the C. C. Wang Family Collection

Maxwell K. Hearn and Wen C. Fong (1999) · Free PDF and online reading from the Metropolitan Museum of Art.

This free Metropolitan Museum catalogue supplies a second point of reference for the Chinese landscape in the selection. Its close object discussions also show how format, inscription and attribution enter the study of a painting.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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